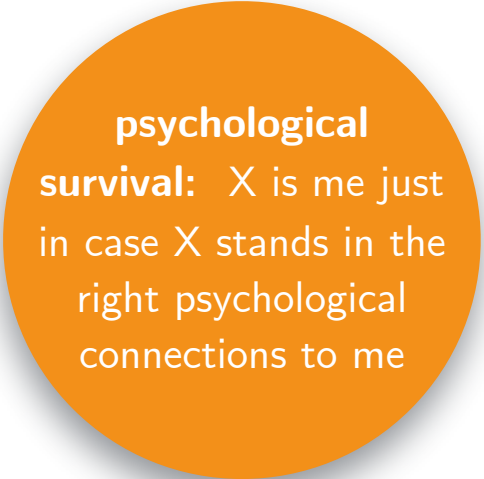


Is life after
death
possible?

Matters are less clear when it comes to our other answers
to the survival question.

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing white text.

psychological
survival: X is me just
in case X stands in the
right psychological
connections to me

soul survival:

X is me just in case

X is the same

immaterial soul as

me

organism

survival: X is me
just in case X is the
same organism as
me

combination

survival: X is me
just in case X is the
combination of my
soul and my body

brain survival: X
is me just in case X
is the same brain as
me

These views differ in important ways, but they all agree that your survival depends on the survival of a certain physical thing.

Views of this kind face an obvious problem in making sense of the possibility of life after death. After death bodies decay (or are cremated). Doesn't that just show that the relevant physical objects won't survive your death — and so that, if one of the above views is right, you won't?

This is a problem which has long troubled philosophers in
the Christian tradition.

This might sound surprising. After all, don't Christians believe that one's immaterial soul is enough for life after death?

In fact, this is not the traditional Christian view. The following quote from Aquinas is representative:

“The necessity of holding the resurrection arises from this — that man may obtain the last end for which he was made. This cannot be accomplished in this life, nor in the life of the separated soul ... it is necessary for the selfsame man to rise again; and this is effected by the selfsame soul being united to the selfsame body. For otherwise there would be no resurrection properly speaking, if the same man were not reformed.”

This is also implied by the use of the word “resurrection”
— if life after death were simply the continued existence
of an immaterial soul, then there would be nothing
needing to be “raised up.”

How can we make sense of this idea, given obvious facts
about the decay of bodies and brains after death?

One idea (defended by Aquinas and others) is that at the time of resurrection our bodies could be **reassembled** by God. While it is true that our bodies decay after death, the material of which they were composed does not cease to exist. Surely an omnipotent being could then simply reassemble our bodies out of the matter from which they were composed when we were living.

Would this be enough for God to bring our bodies back
into existence?

There are various problems of detail here. (For example, Aquinas worried a lot about cannibalism, which would seem to make certain bits of matter part of more than one person.) But we have already seen that there is a purely philosophical problem with this idea.

Remember the case of the Ship of Theseus. We saw that there is good reason to believe that Original Ship = Continuous Ship. (If this were not so, it is hard to see how our bodies could continue to exist over time despite gaining and losing parts.)

But we also saw that if this is true, Original Ship $\neq$ Reconstructed Ship. And if this is so, that would seem to imply that if a material thing breaks into its constituent parts, reassembling those parts does **not** bring the original material thing back into existence.

And that seems to imply that, even if God did reassemble the parts which formerly composed some body (or brain), that would not be enough to bring that very body (or brain) back into existence.

This is a serious problem for the idea of “resurrection as reassembly.” Is there any other way to make sense of the idea of a bodily resurrection?

It is fair to say that there is no generally accepted answer
to this question.

But here is a strategy that some Christian materialists have tried. First, we point out that there is no reason why we should be able to figure out how God brings about the resurrection. (It is, after all, supposed to be a miracle.)

Second, we try to give some story — no matter how unlikely — which shows that there would be no impossibility in doing this. Here's an example, from Peter van Inwagen.

“... I proposed a solution to this problem that has, let us say, not won wide assent. ... I suggested that God could accomplish the resurrection of, say, Socrates, in the following way. He could have, in 399 BC, miraculously translated Socrates' fresh corpse to some distant place for safe-keeping (at the same time removing the hemlock and undoing the physiological damage it had done) and have replaced it with a simulacrum, a perfect physical duplicate of Socrates' corpse; later, on the day of resurrection, he could reanimate Socrates' corpse, and the reanimated corpse, no longer a corpse but once more a living organism, would be Socrates.”

The idea is not that this is what in fact happens — the aim is the more limited one of showing that there is no impossibility in it happening in this way.



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